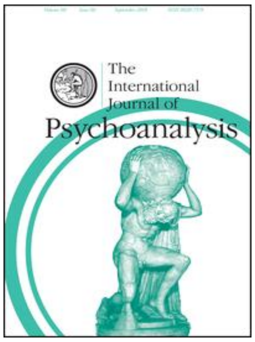

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Response to Kessler, Sandberg, and Busch: The case for and against neuropsychoanalysis

Dear Editor,

In our 2015 paper, "Further evidence for the case against neuropsychoanalysis" as well as in our earlier work on this topic (Blass and Carmeli, 2007; Carmeli and Blass, 2013), we present arguments that show that despite the existence of obvious and proven ties between brain and mind, neuroscience has no contribution to psychoanalysis; moreover, it can never have any.

Luba Kessler in her letter states that something must be amiss with our position, but only offers yet another formulation of the tie between brain and mind. She does not take issue with a single one of our arguments regarding the irrelevance of such ties to psychoanalysis and thus her reflections don't really address our critique.

For example, her comments about how a neuroscientifically informed psychoanalyst would understand Ms A do not in any way support the idea that being so informed is worthwhile. She speaks of Ms A's trauma as a known fact which "undoubtedly" had certain specific effects both psychological and physiological. However, from the description of the case the reality of this trauma was precisely what was in doubt. But even assuming it happened (and we accept that it may have) how should the specific neuroscientific findings on the effects of trauma on the hippocampus impact us as psychoanalysts? An example of how neuroscience might shape what the analyst says or does in the treatment of Ms A would have been most helpful here. Instead, Kessler offers a very general theoretical comment, which does not advance our understanding. She agrees with us that the "psychoanalyst needs to preserve the conceptual and clinical integrity of her clinical and theoretical discipline", but at the same time maintains that there is some "conceptual richness offered by judiciously managed insights from the neurosciences" that remains to be gained. Her comments on the crucial question of the nature of this richness were, unfortunately, unintelligible to us. She writes that biology enriches "both fields of inquiry",

> because it encompasses the body AND the psyche. Indeed one can argue that the care of psychoanalytic rigor is especially important BECAUSE the psyche is deeply implicated in the homeostatic management of the human organism it inhabits. The fact that same may apply to the neuronal structure such as the hippocampus does not replace it but rather serves to illuminates [*sic*].

A convincing clinical illustration or a more cogent argument is needed to meaningfully counter the detailed position we offered in our paper regarding the irrelevance of physiological findings – however, well-founded they may be – to the analyst's clinical work.

Larry S. Sandberg, in his letter, believes that he provides just such an illustration. He describes how reading neuroscientific literature which questioned what could be explicitly remembered following trauma helped him take note of his patient's defensive sense of certainty and projection into him of uncertainty, which could then be interpreted. However, the specific neuroscientific finding mentioned in his reading, namely, on how "hippocampal damage due to early trauma impacted declarative memory systems" seems to serve here no more than an inspirational role; it stimulated Sandberg's associative processes. Perhaps the fact that it's a scientific finding, authoritative in its own field, made it particularly stimulating for Sandberg, but it did not in any direct way actually shape his interpretation. In other words, the fact that Sandberg's interpretation was inspired by neuroscience says nothing about the real value of neuroscience to psychoanalysis and, in fact, does not rely on any real research having been carried out. E.g., if the question regarding memory were raised in the book without mentioning neuroscience, or if the results were fabricated it could, in principle, have been just as inspiring, just as consequential.

In another of our papers (Carmeli and Blass, 2013) we discussed precisely this kind of misguided attempt to support the relevance of neuroscience to psychoanalysis, focusing on Norman Doidge's claim that neuroscientific findings have been used to develop rehabilitation programmes for psychological deficiencies. Reviewing his presentation of the case of Barbara Arrowsmith Young we concluded that "Barbara's reading about brain research apparently had an impact on her rehabilitation process, but it was not the neuroscientific contents of what she read that played the crucial role" (p. 395). Rather she was *inspired* by the research: "It served for Barbara as a sort of motto: 'the brain could be modified'" (ibid.).

Here it is important to recognize that there are innumerable things that can be helpful to analytic practice in this inspirational kind of way without the effect being "categorical or predictable" and that neuroscience has no special status in this regard. Relaxation, exercise, and various forms of leisurely activities are common sources of inspiration that can further insightful analytic thinking. Like these practices, the study of neuroscience should not be discouraged. However, it should be clear that like these practices there is no reason at all for psychoanalysis to encourage it either.

And yet Sandberg seems to award neuroscience some special status. It were as though he can't let go of a belief that neuroscience *must* have some special value for psychoanalysis; that there is a baby there that is in danger of getting tossed out with the bathwater as a result of our critique. How else can one understand how Sandberg, (similarly to Kessler), refers to our antagonism to neuroscience, while failing to provide any evidence at all to back up his claim that the complete rejection of the relevance of neuroscience to psychoanalysis is premature? To actually ground his claim he would have to seriously take issue with our argument (which we develop in detail in all our papers) that the essential relationship between the fields is such that by definition neuroscience can never be relevant to psychoanalysis (Blass and Carmeli, 2007, 2015; Carmeli and Blass, 2013).

In fact, Sandberg's final comment, which makes a parallel between the analyst and the art restorer, brings to the fore his gross neglect of this argument. Our argument makes clear why the analyst's role is precisely *not* comparable to that of the art restorer; how the nature of the analyst's concern with meaning is such that the understanding of physical matter and how it can be manipulated is irrelevant to him. Indeed, the analyst might be said to aim at restoration but, as we explain, this is a restoration of *meaning* for which analytic understanding alone is needed (just as the artist needs artistic capacities). The *physical* restoration that might be possible through neurosurgery or medication and relies on neuroscientific knowledge is what's analogous to the role of the art restorer. In failing to distinguish between what we have shown in our paper to be two very different senses of restoration, and in analogy of cure, Sandberg simply ignores our most basic point.

Frederic N. Busch's letter similarly overlooks our key points. He maintains that our negative attitude towards neuroscience is like the negative attitude analysts used to have towards medication being introduced into analytic treatment. But medication is now commonly and beneficially applied in analytic treatments. He goes on to assert that the effectiveness of medication impacts the understanding of intrapsychic dynamics and that medication should be regarded as an analytic intervention. However, at the very heart of our paper is the claim that the fact that medication can reduce symptoms of the kind that may also be effected by analytic interventions says nothing about the relevance of biology for analytic understanding, or about the analytic nature of biological interventions. Our paper offers detailed arguments explaining why, even though the individual may always be understood in terms of his neurology and his state of mind may often be impacted neurologically, neuroscience cannot deepen our understanding of unconscious meanings. And it is precisely the understanding of unconscious meanings that is the essence of the analytic process. To analyze is to choose to understand the person in this way over other available ways of understanding him. Unfortunately, Busch does not take issue with our arguments, nor does he offer evidence that opposes our positions.

Perhaps this has to do with his problematic basic assumption regarding the nature of the person and of psychoanalysis. Busch seems to think that the kind of understanding that should be applied to deal with human predicaments is determined by the nature of the predicament. The person may have neurological problems or psychoanalytic ones (he may have a defective piano or be a defective pianist). When neurology is applicable the analyst needs to *expand* his role to include it. This assumption runs counter to the view that we have argued for in our paper; namely, that the person is always open to being understood in multiple ways: neurological, psychoanalytical, behavioral, sociological, philosophical, theological, etc. Except for situations in which the person is so severely damaged that he is not capable of generating meaning, neurological or psychoanalytical intervention is a matter of choice. Crucial here is the fact that Busch doesn't consider the move to the neurological level, which we agree at times may be necessary, to be extra-analytic, but rather integral to psychoanalysis. But here one must ask: What definition of psychoanalysis does he adopt to support this view? Does he regard as analytic any intervention that alleviates symptoms (including behavioral methods)? Anything that furthers the analytic process (e.g., including the patient getting a job which allows him to pay for the analysis)? Or is it specifically biological understanding and intervention that must be considered psychoanalytic? Busch doesn't explicitly present his definition of psychoanalysis. But it is clear that if one adopts his limited position on how the person can be understood (whereby the nature of the event determines the kind of understanding that is possible) together with very broad position on the nature of psychoanalysis of the kind that he suggests, then the relevance of neuroscience to psychoanalysis is clear and even obvious, but it also tells us nothing meaningful. Nothing uniquely psychoanalytic remains to which neuroscience could be relevant.

Sincerely,

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